From customer concern to cloud capability - complete text version

Your success in a sales team depends on listening carefully to what customers say about their business challenges, and then connecting those needs to the right cloud capability. In this activity you are an entry-level sales associate preparing for discovery calls. You will study a reference sheet of common concerns, then work through four customer scenarios: identify the business need, choose the cloud capability that answers it and explain your reasoning to the customer. You will finish by recalling the pairings without the sheet. For each scenario, first identify the customer's business need, then choose the cloud capability that best addresses it, then write a short explanation in your own words and compare it with a model answer. If a choice is not right, the feedback explains why and you can try again. The businesses are fictional. This activity is not scored, and nothing you choose or write is stored or sent anywhere unless you save a text file yourself. Allow about 20 minutes.

How to use this version

You can do every stage on paper or in a document. Read each scenario, choose the business need, choose the cloud capability that addresses it, then write one or two sentences explaining why it fits and compare them with the model answer. Read the feedback for every option and compare it with your choices. If you chose differently, work out why before moving on. At the end, recall the pairings without looking at the reference sheet.

Cloud solutions reference sheet

Common client concerns, the business needs behind them, and the cloud capabilities that address them. Use the sheet to guide your answers.

- Client concern: "Our systems can't handle peak demand." Business need: Limited scalability. Cloud capability: Elastic computing and auto-scaling.
- Client concern: "We're worried about protecting customer data." Business need: Data security concerns. Cloud capability: Encryption, identity management and compliance controls.
- Client concern: "We're spending too much on maintaining servers." Business need: High infrastructure costs. Cloud capability: Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation.
- Client concern: "It takes us months to launch new products." Business need: Slow time to market. Cloud capability: Automated deployment and development and operations, or DevOps, integration.

- Client concern: “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” Business need: Lack of data backup or disaster recovery. Cloud capability: Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services.

Scenario 1 of 4: A growing logistics company

A small logistics company has recently secured several new contracts and expects its business volume to double within the next year. However, its existing technology systems are already struggling to keep up, and it has reached out to your organisation for help. During a discovery call with the leadership team, one manager says: “We need a solution that can grow with us without constant investment in new servers or hardware.”

A. Identify the business need.

- Scalability - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The manager highlights a scalability challenge: they need a system that can expand as the organisation grows without continuous investment in new servers or hardware.
- Security and compliance - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. If security were the main issue, the manager would have raised concerns about protecting data, controlling access or compliance risks.
- Cost control and efficiency - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The manager does mention reducing repeated investment, but cost control is not the primary concern.
- Faster time to market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time to market is the need behind concerns like “It takes us months to launch new products.” This customer is describing growing capacity without buying more hardware.
- Backup and disaster recovery - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Backup and disaster recovery is the need behind concerns like “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This customer is describing growing capacity without buying more hardware.

B. Choose the cloud capability that best addresses that need.

Think about what lets cloud systems adjust automatically when demand rises and falls.

- Elastic computing and auto-scaling - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Elastic computing and auto-scaling answers concerns like “Our systems can’t handle peak demand.”
- Encryption, identity management and compliance controls - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Encryption, identity management and compliance controls answers a different concern: “We’re worried about protecting customer data.” This customer is describing growing capacity without buying more hardware.

- Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation answers a different concern: “We’re spending too much on maintaining servers.” This customer is describing growing capacity without buying more hardware.
- Automated deployment and DevOps integration - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Automated deployment and DevOps integration answers a different concern: “It takes us months to launch new products.” This customer is describing growing capacity without buying more hardware.
- Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services answers a different concern: “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This customer is describing growing capacity without buying more hardware.

C. Explain it to the customer

C. In one or two sentences, explain to the customer why this capability fits. Then compare your answer with the model answer. Model answer: Elastic computing and auto-scaling are ideal cloud capabilities for this challenge. Elastic computing lets resources such as processing power and storage expand or contract automatically with demand. Auto-scaling complements it by adjusting the number of active servers to maintain performance. Together they let the system handle fluctuating workloads consistently, without large upfront hardware investments.

Scenario 2 of 4: A regional healthcare provider

A regional healthcare provider has managed its patient information on its own on-site systems for several years. As it expands its network of clinics and increases patient volume, the technology is becoming difficult to maintain and secure. Leadership has decided to move its patient management system to the cloud to improve accessibility and reliability. During a discovery call, the Chief Information Officer says: “Our top priority is keeping patient data safe and compliant with all healthcare regulations. We can’t risk any data breaches or violations during this transition.”

A. Identify the business need.

- Scalability - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The focus is not on expanding capacity or handling more data efficiently, but on protecting sensitive data and meeting strict compliance requirements.
- Security and compliance - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The organisation’s primary need is making sure sensitive patient information stays secure and compliant with healthcare regulations, during and after the move to the cloud.
- Cost control and efficiency - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Managing costs is always a factor, but the main concern here is data protection and adherence to healthcare standards, not reducing operating expenses.

- Faster time to market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time to market is the need behind concerns like “It takes us months to launch new products.” This customer is describing keeping patient data safe and compliant.
- Backup and disaster recovery - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Backup and disaster recovery is the need behind concerns like “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This customer is describing keeping patient data safe and compliant.

B. Choose the cloud capability that best addresses that need.

Consider which capabilities protect sensitive information and help meet industry compliance requirements.

- Elastic computing and auto-scaling - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Elastic computing and auto-scaling answers a different concern: “Our systems can’t handle peak demand.” This customer is describing keeping patient data safe and compliant.
- Encryption, identity management and compliance controls - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Encryption, identity management and compliance controls answers concerns like “We’re worried about protecting customer data.”
- Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation answers a different concern: “We’re spending too much on maintaining servers.” This customer is describing keeping patient data safe and compliant.
- Automated deployment and DevOps integration - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Automated deployment and DevOps integration answers a different concern: “It takes us months to launch new products.” This customer is describing keeping patient data safe and compliant.
- Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services answers a different concern: “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This customer is describing keeping patient data safe and compliant.

C. Explain it to the customer

C. In one or two sentences, explain to the customer why this capability fits. Then compare your answer with the model answer. Model answer: Advanced security and compliance features are the ideal capabilities for this challenge. They include encryption, identity and access management, and detailed audit logging. Together these controls help safeguard sensitive patient data, make sure only authorised people have access and maintain compliance with healthcare regulations, so the provider can move to the cloud with confidence.

Scenario 3 of 4: A growing retail business

A small but growing retail business has run its systems on ageing physical servers for years. The servers need constant maintenance, frequent upgrades and expensive software licences, and technology expenses are consuming a large part of the annual budget, leaving little room for innovation. During a discovery meeting, the operations manager says: “We’re spending too much just to keep our systems running. We need a more affordable and flexible approach, something that lets us pay only for what we actually use, without massive upfront investments.”

A. Identify the business need.

- Scalability - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Scalability is a benefit of cloud computing, but this scenario emphasises financial concerns, reducing maintenance and capital costs, rather than growth in capacity.
- Security and compliance - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The company does not mention data protection or regulatory issues. Its main pain point is the financial strain of maintaining outdated infrastructure.
- Cost control and efficiency - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The business is focused on reducing technology expenses and moving away from large upfront infrastructure costs. It needs spending that follows actual usage, to improve cost efficiency and cash flow.
- Faster time to market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time to market is the need behind concerns like “It takes us months to launch new products.” This customer is describing spending too much to keep ageing systems running.
- Backup and disaster recovery - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Backup and disaster recovery is the need behind concerns like “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This customer is describing spending too much to keep ageing systems running.

B. Choose the cloud capability that best addresses that need.

Consider how cloud services help businesses avoid large upfront costs and instead charge based on actual usage.

- Elastic computing and auto-scaling - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Elastic computing and auto-scaling answers a different concern: “Our systems can’t handle peak demand.” This customer is describing spending too much to keep ageing systems running.
- Encryption, identity management and compliance controls - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Encryption, identity management and compliance controls answers a different concern: “We’re worried about protecting customer data.” This customer is describing spending too much to keep ageing systems running.

- Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation answers concerns like “We’re spending too much on maintaining servers.”
- Automated deployment and DevOps integration - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Automated deployment and DevOps integration answers a different concern: “It takes us months to launch new products.” This customer is describing spending too much to keep ageing systems running.
- Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services answers a different concern: “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This customer is describing spending too much to keep ageing systems running.

C. Explain it to the customer

C. In one or two sentences, explain to the customer why this capability fits. Then compare your answer with the model answer. Model answer: Pay-as-you-go pricing and cost optimisation are the ideal capabilities for this challenge. Pay-as-you-go lets an organisation pay only for the resources it actually uses, with no large upfront investment in hardware or licences. Combined with cost management tools and usage monitoring, spending stays flexible, predictable and aligned with business activity.

Scenario 4 of 4: A small architecture firm

A small architecture firm keeps all of its client drawings and project files on a single server in its office. The server is several years old. During a discovery call, the managing director says: “If that server fails, we could lose everything, and nobody could work until it was replaced.”

A. Identify the business need.

- Scalability - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Scalability is the need behind concerns like “Our systems can’t handle peak demand.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.
- Security and compliance - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Security and compliance is the need behind concerns like “We’re worried about protecting customer data.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.
- Cost control and efficiency - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cost control and efficiency is the need behind concerns like “We’re spending too much on maintaining servers.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.
- Faster time to market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time to market is the need behind concerns like “It takes us months to launch new products.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.

- Backup and disaster recovery - Best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Backup and disaster recovery is the need behind concerns like “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.

B. Choose the cloud capability that best addresses that need.

Think about how cloud services keep copies of data in more than one place and restore access after a failure.

- Elastic computing and auto-scaling - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Elastic computing and auto-scaling answers a different concern: “Our systems can’t handle peak demand.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.
- Encryption, identity management and compliance controls - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Encryption, identity management and compliance controls answers a different concern: “We’re worried about protecting customer data.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.
- Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation answers a different concern: “We’re spending too much on maintaining servers.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.
- Automated deployment and DevOps integration - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Automated deployment and DevOps integration answers a different concern: “It takes us months to launch new products.” This customer is describing losing everything if one server fails.
- Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services answers concerns like “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.”

C. Explain it to the customer

C. In one or two sentences, explain to the customer why this capability fits. Then compare your answer with the model answer. Model answer: Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services are the ideal capabilities for this challenge. Redundancy keeps copies of the firm’s files in more than one place, and disaster recovery services let it restore access quickly after a failure, so one failed server no longer means lost work.

Recall the pairings

The reference sheet is now closed. Open it only if you need it. For each customer concern, choose the cloud capability that addresses it.

Concern 1 of 3

“It takes us months to launch new products.”

- Elastic computing and auto-scaling - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Elastic computing and auto-scaling answers a different concern: “Our systems can’t handle peak demand.” This concern is about slow launches.
- Encryption, identity management and compliance controls - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Encryption, identity management and compliance controls answers a different concern: “We’re worried about protecting customer data.” This concern is about slow launches.
- Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation answers a different concern: “We’re spending too much on maintaining servers.” This concern is about slow launches.
- Automated deployment and DevOps integration - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Automated deployment and DevOps integration.
- Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services answers a different concern: “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This concern is about slow launches.

Concern 2 of 3

“Our website slows down every time we run a promotion.”

- Elastic computing and auto-scaling - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Elastic computing and auto-scaling.
- Encryption, identity management and compliance controls - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Encryption, identity management and compliance controls answers a different concern: “We’re worried about protecting customer data.” This concern is about handling peaks in demand.
- Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation answers a different concern: “We’re spending too much on maintaining servers.” This concern is about handling peaks in demand.
- Automated deployment and DevOps integration - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Automated deployment and DevOps integration answers a different concern: “It takes us months to launch new products.” This concern is about handling peaks in demand.
- Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services answers a different concern: “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This concern is about handling peaks in demand.

Concern 3 of 3

“Customers keep asking where their data is stored and who can see it.”

- Elastic computing and auto-scaling - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Elastic computing and auto-scaling answers a different concern: “Our systems can’t handle peak demand.” This concern is about protecting customer data.
- Encryption, identity management and compliance controls - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Encryption, identity management and compliance controls.
- Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation answers a different concern: “We’re spending too much on maintaining servers.” This concern is about protecting customer data.
- Automated deployment and DevOps integration - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Automated deployment and DevOps integration answers a different concern: “It takes us months to launch new products.” This concern is about protecting customer data.
- Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services answers a different concern: “If our system goes down, we could lose everything.” This concern is about protecting customer data.

Reflect and save

You matched customer needs to cloud capabilities. Here is a summary of your matches.

- A growing logistics company: Scalability, addressed by Elastic computing and auto-scaling.
- A regional healthcare provider: Security and compliance, addressed by Encryption, identity management and compliance controls.
- A growing retail business: Cost control and efficiency, addressed by Pay-as-you-go pricing and resource optimisation.
- A small architecture firm: Backup and disaster recovery, addressed by Cloud storage redundancy and disaster recovery services.

Choose the pairing you would find hardest to remember. Write the customer concern and the capability in a sentence you could say on a discovery call. In the interactive version, Save my summary downloads your matches, your explanations and your reflection as a text file. An empty reflection prompts: Write a short reflection before saving. Connecting what a customer says to a cloud capability, and explaining why, is how you turn a concern into a conversation about value.